With Lashkar's assistance, those Indians who had not fled or been arrested began a recruitment drive and also maintained a low-level bombing campaign.[123] SIMI provided many of the early recruits who, motivated by appeals to Muslim identity rather than the Kashmir conflict, sought out Pakistani jihadi groups. When stating that Lashkar recruited through SIMI it is important to be clear that SIMI was, and remained, independent of Lashkar. It had its own agenda, albeit one that linked local Indian grievances to the wider jihadi movement. No group had a monopoly on SIMI's operatives and it is not correct to say that SIMI provided operatives to Lashkar. A more precise explanation would be that Lashkar used some of SIMI's network as a recruiting pool, co-opting its cadres to provide manpower or support for operations. Lashkar sent many of those it recruited from 1993 onwards to its camps for training. During this stage, Lashkar was also providing funding, planning, direction and ideological support for its burgeoning Indian networks as well.

According to Praveen Swami, among the foremost experts on Indian jihadi networks, Indians were executing attacks, with Lashkar assigning Pakistani operatives to help build the bombs and provide other expertise.[124] By the mid-1990s, Cheema is believed to have been running over a dozen Pakistani Lashkar operatives across India.[125] As Indian actors became more capable, they assumed greater responsibility for operations. For example, when Tunda returned to India he became Lashkar's operational commander there as well as one of its premier bomb-makers and explosives trainers.[126] Ghouri came back to India in 1998, having spent considerable time based in Saudi Arabia, where he was in contact with several Lashkar operatives and helped to develop the group's Gulf networks.[127] According to statements made to the Indian security services by one captured Indian Lashkar operative, Ghouri had also traveled to Pakistan to train with the group since fleeing India in 1994.[128] When Ghouri did return to his native Hyderabad to build up Lashkar's networks, recruitment experienced a boost.[129] An attendant increase in bombings followed, mainly targeting civilian areas such as trains, buses and markets. Police finally caught up with and killed Ghouri in April 2000, but as subsequent chapters will indicate, since then bombing attacks by Lashkar-trained and supported Indians have only increased. Its ability to finance these and other operations as well as to support them logistically was partly a function of its presence in the Gulf.